KISHEN SHASTRY

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FIELDS OF INTEREST

Primary	Development Economics, Economics of Religion and Informal Institutions
Secondary	Political Economy, Economics of Digital Technologies and Platforms
Methods	Applied Microeconometrics and Causal Inference

EDUCATION

University of Cambridge *2021–2026*
Ph.D. in Economics, Jesus College. Conferred July 2026.
Thesis: "Essays in the Economics of Institutions"
Supervisor: Sriya Iyer; Advisor: Toke Aidt

University of Cambridge *2020–2021*
M.Phil. in Economic Research, Jesus College

The Graduate Institute Geneva *2018–2020*
Masters in International Economics

National Institute of Technology Karnataka *2012–2016*
B.Tech. in Computer Engineering

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

University of Cambridge *2026–Present*
Postdoctoral Research Associate, Cambridge Centre for Alternative Finance, Judge Business School
Research on digital identity, e-KYC and digital public infrastructure in emerging markets.

PUBLICATIONS

Religion, Covid-19 and Mental Health (with G. Bahal, S. Iyer & A. Shrivastava)
***European Economic Review**, Vol. 160 (2023) [Link]*
Using an original survey of 5,178 US respondents and the CES-D depression scale, we show that Covid-19 infection is associated with significantly worse mental health, and that this association is attenuated for religious individuals through participation in religious activities.

WORKING PAPERS

Religious Institutions and Economic Development in India (Job Market Paper)
I assemble a new geocoded dataset on 253 Hindu monastic institutions (*mutts*) in Karnataka and link it to subdistrict and constituency panel data from SHRUG. A difference-in-differences design exploiting pre-1990 mutt exposure and the timing of liberalisation and democratic decentralisation shows that mutt-exposed areas experience faster structural transformation out of agriculture, larger gains in nonfarm and skilled employment, greater provision of secondary schools, colleges and hostels per capita, and tighter electoral competition. The results show how identity-based religious organisations can act as local development institutions.

Open Transaction Networks and Platform Competition (with P. Belleflamme, S. Shrivastav, D. Rinaldo & J.-L. Arcand)
August 2026 [Link]
We develop a two-sided Hotelling model in which competing platforms choose whether to adopt a shared open protocol on the buyer side, the seller side, both, or neither, motivated by India's ONDC. Contrary to the standard underinvestment result, full interoperability emerges as a dominant-strategy equilibrium, because compliance expands users' trading opportunities and softens competition for exclusive control over users. Much of the profit gain is a transfer, since opening the network lets platforms withdraw the cross-side subsidies conceded under exclusivity. Users gain only when the newly reachable pools are sufficiently valuable, so a planner weighing users alone often prefers compliance on a single side.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Gatherings and Epidemics (with G. Bahal, S. Iyer & A. Shrivastava)
We estimate the causal effect of in-person mass gatherings on Covid-19 transmission in the United States. Text classification on over 700,000 local newspaper articles yields a county-week index of reported gatherings. A shift-share instrument interacting counties' pre-Covid propensity to generate gatherings news with the timing of Black Lives Matter protests identifies the effect: an instrumented one-standard-deviation increase in gatherings coverage raises new cases one to two weeks later, with heterogeneity by density, partisanship and baseline gatherings intensity.

POLICY PUBLICATIONS AND WHITE PAPERS

SCORE Strand 3 White Paper on Religions and Economic Development (with S. Iyer, K. Iljina, M. Wiemann & C. Powell)
Cambridge Working Papers in Economics No. 2645 (2026), 135pp. [Link]
Interdisciplinary assessment of the evidence on how religious beliefs, institutions, networks and practices interact with economic and human development. Launched at St Catharine's College, Cambridge, July 2026.

GRANTS AND FUNDED RESEARCH

Gates Foundation *2025*
Economics of Open Transaction Networks Programme *$1,346,723 USD*
Author of the successful proposal (INV-093368). Programme Lead for the economics workstream, hosted at the Global Development Network. [Link]

Templeton Religion Trust *2024*
SCORE Strand 3: Religions and Economic Development (PI: S. Iyer)
Contributed to proposal development for Strand 3 of a decade-long, $10m programme on the social consequences of religion.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Global Development Network *2024–Present*
Economist and Programme Lead, Economics of Open Transaction Networks *London, UK*

- Lead the economics workstream of a Gates Foundation programme on open transaction networks, developing the theoretical framework on network effects, market structure and welfare, designing the empirical strategy for a cross-country evaluation in India, Brazil and Kenya.

PRESENTATIONS

2026 "Religious Institutions and Economic Development in India", SCORE Strand 3 Conference, University of Cambridge

2023 "Religious Institutions and Economic Development in India", Advanced Graduate Workshop on Poverty, Development and Globalisation, Azim Premji University and the Institute for New Economic Thinking, Bengaluru

2022 ASREC Graduate Student Workshop in the Economics of Religion, Chapman University

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor *2024–Present*
Research Methods: Quantitative *Chanakya University*
Sole instructor for the quantitative methods course on the Chanakya Fellowship, covering statistical inference, estimation and empirical research design, with applied sessions in R.

Supervisor *2023, 2024*
Economics of Developing Countries (Part IIB) *University of Cambridge*
Small-group supervisions and teaching for third-year undergraduates.

FELLOWSHIPS, AWARDS AND HONOURS

2022	**ASREC Graduate Student Workshop**, selected participant (10 worldwide)	
2022	**Adam Smith Fellowship**, Mercatus Center	$10,000
2021	**Cambridge Trust Scholarship**	£80,000
2021	**Cambridge Nehru Bursary**	£45,000
2020	**Narotam Sekhsaria Foundation Scholarship**	£15,000
2018	**Hans Wilsdorf Foundation Scholarship**	$52,000
2017	**Young India Fellowship**, Ashoka University	$8,000

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Referee: *Scottish Journal of Political Economy*, *PLOS ONE*

SKILLS

Software R (Advanced), Stata (Advanced), QGIS (Advanced), Python, LaTeX

Languages English (Fluent), Kannada (Fluent), French (A2)

REFERENCES

Professor Sriya Iyer
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Professor Toke Aidt
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Professor Mohamed Saleh
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Professor Jean-Louis Arcand
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